QUEEN OF THE BOARD

Like most chess prodigies, Vaishali shone on the 64 squares from an early age

Vaishali wins Girls' World Youth Chess Championship Under-12 (2012) and Under-14 (2015) titles	Makes headlines after beating Magnus Carlsen in a simultaneous exhibition match in Chennai in 2013
Wins FIDE Grand Swiss tournament in 2023, qualifies for Candidates 2024	Becomes a GM in 2023, only the third Indian woman—after Koneru Humpy and Harika Dronavalli—to get the title
Plays board two at 45th Chess Olympiad in 2024 where the Indian women win their first gold medal	In her 2024 Candidates debut, after a tough first half, wins five matches in a row to finish joint second
Arjuna Award winner in 2024, the 7th woman chess player to do so. Chess stars have won over 20 awards	Wins 2025 FIDE Grand Swiss tournament title to seal a spot at Candidates 2026
Wins Candidates 2026 to become challenger for world champion crown. Second Indian woman after Humpy	Will take on five-time Chinese world champion Ju Wenjun early next year

To play in the soundproof glass enclosure against the best in the world has long been Vaishali's dream. "Both siblings wanted to be world champions," says their coach R.B. Ramesh, who was India-bound after watching his protégé take the top spot in Cyprus. It wasn't just that Vaishali won the toughest classical chess tournament featuring a top-tier field, it's the way she did it which was a source of pride for Ramesh. "In the first half [seven matches], she was struggling. Then she settled down and started believing in herself more," he said, singling out her wins against compatriot and World Cup winner Divya Deshmukh and Russian grandmaster Aleksandra Goryachkina. "Against Divya, she avoided her opening preparation and just tried to play the game, and with Goryachkina, she played a good positional game, kept the pressure on and induced a mistake."

BORN TO SHINE

Vaishali was 11 and Pragg had just won the under-8 world title when they walked into Ramesh's academy, Chess Gurukul, in 2014. "They were very strong players already," he noted. "Vaishali was very hardworking and a good attacking player." Prod him on what made the siblings excel, and he attributes the success to their parents. Nagalakshmi would accompany the kids daily on their hour-long commute by bus to the academy. "They don't put much pressure on them," he says. "One huge mistake most parents make is that they raise the bar too high in terms of expectations. Just because they want something good to happen doesn't mean it will. The outcome of that is frustration. With these two, they had the freedom to play chess the way they wanted."

The petite, sari-clad Nagalakshmi is a familiar face at tournaments, offering emotional support and even cooking sambhar and rasam for the kids in foreign landscapes. From the beginning, Rameshbabu, who had already overcome the challenges of childhood polio and made a career as a bank manager, took on the job of managing both children's careers with enthusiasm. "Our father is our biggest strength," Vaishali said, talking to the media in Cyprus.. "He has made a lot of sacrifices." In a rare interview to website, ChessBase India, Rameshbabu, too, spoke of the financial strain of supporting two professional chess players, ensuring they had everything they needed as they pursued their passion.

> **"There is little pressure on Vaishali and Pragg from the parents, so they have the freedom to play the way they want. They are among the most hard-working players I know"**
>
> **R.B. RAMESH,** *Coach*



That Vaishali was a generational talent was well known in chess circles. And not just on the board, but off it too. "Every game is new in its own way, you find an interesting line, an idea, sometimes even sacrificing a piece gives me a lot of joy," she told the FIDE channel. It wasn't a surprise then that Vaishali was one of the first four GMs—and the only woman—invited to join the WestBridge Anand Chess Academy (WACA) when it started in December 2020. "I was impressed with the level of her game," says former world champion and WACA co-founder Viswanathan Anand. "Over time, as I got to know her, I realised she also has great tenacity. Even when she is struggling in a tournament, she is able to keep it together and keep playing. She doesn't crumble under pressure."